

THE LONGSTREET SOCIETY

An Academic Guide to the Piedmont Hotel

AN ACADEMIC PHOTO GALLERY COMPILED BY
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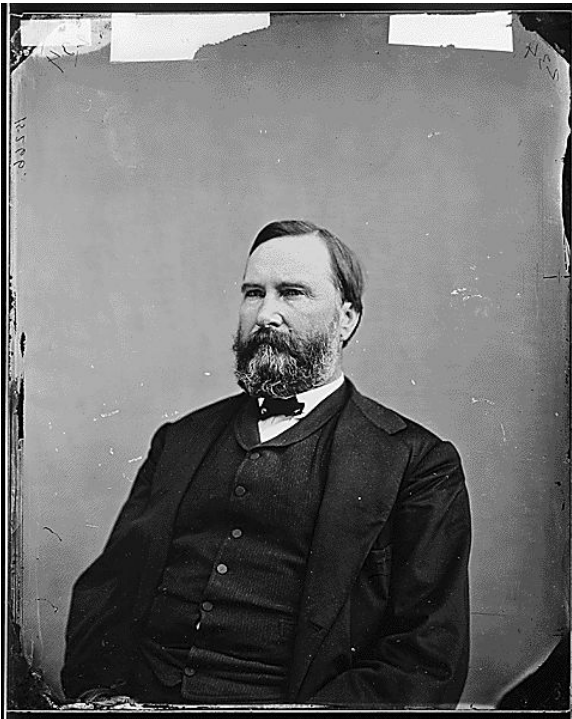
Table of Contents

Introduction	3
The Post Bellum Life of General James Longstreet and its role in the Piedmont Hotel	
Part I — The Overall Narrative	
Taking the Impossible: Rehabilitation of a Reconstructed Confederate Rebel	7
Providing the Reality: Rehabilitation of an Unreconstructed Confederate Rebel	8
Part II — Public History	
The Museum Hallway: Retelling General Longstreet's Story	12
The Longstreet Library: Accessibility and James Longstreet	14
The "Awkward" Rooms: The Hijacking of Narrative	15
Judge Norton's Space: History's Endemic Financial Obstacles	16
Further Reading	20

THE POST BELLUM LIFE OF General James Longstreet

AND ITS ROLE IN THE PIEDMONT HOTEL

History has taught us that the American Civil War was an unfortunate era in our nation's history marked by viscous fighting over the South's white supremacy, chattel slavery, and maintenance of a social hierarchy designed to keep wealthy plantation owners in control. This pedagogy has produced a simple teaching mold to understand the war: the leaders of the South were the bad guys and the leaders of the North were the good guys. But understanding the war, or any concept in the past, can never be that simple in the end. History is marked by the contours of the past — by the individuals that do not fit within their defined group, whether it be a group defined by contemporary society or by society of the past.

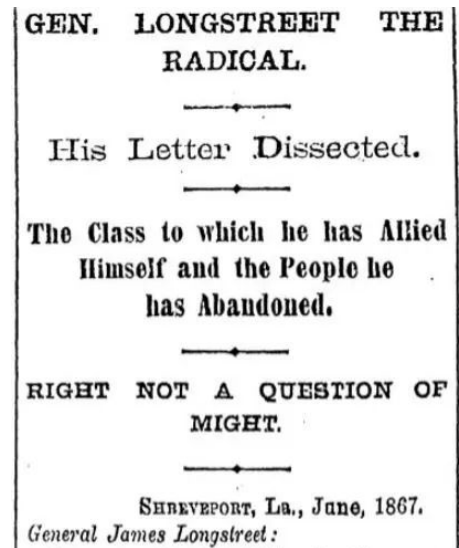


Youthful James Longstreet

After the Civil War, Confederate General James Longstreet would settle in New Orleans where a significant portion of his battalion was from and where many other generals left to. There, he would pen an editorial to the *New Orleans Times* asking Southerners to accept Reconstruction because “the sword has decided in favor of the North, and what they claimed as principles cease to be principles, and are become law.” Longstreet had effectively told the South to relinquish the claim of slavery and disenfranchisement to a region occupied by White supremacists — a feat that would end disastrously for the former Confederate General.

Conservative Democrats responded to confront the opinion of their former Confederate leader, writing that he “counsels [them] to the vile infamy of hugging our chains and servilely licking the hands that smite us.” Longstreet had challenged the South's notion that it had a right to disenfranchise non-White voters. His reasoning was irrelevant to those that fought to preserve the institution of slavery and White supremacy — despite his service in their fight for a White racial order.

To be clear, Longstreet was not a racial egalitarian and still harbored White supremacist views in his private letters. His view on Black suffrage was equal among his peers but he splits off from them by disagreeing with reinvigorating a new war with a rejuvenated Confederacy. Longstreet viewed the war as final so that the Southerner was best served by accepting Reconstruction, joining the Republican Party, and being active in federal politics instead of continuing the nostalgia of their famed rebellious Confederacy. Few in the South had signed onto this belief.



General Grant would offer to speak to President Johnson on granting Longstreet his citizenship back after the 14th Amendment was ratified. Grant and Longstreet were very intimate friends when they attended West Point academy together. Johnson was hesitant, saying to Longstreet that there are “three persons of the South who can never receive amnesty: Mr. Davis, General Lee, and yourself.” Congress was more forgiving to Longstreet, and he was restored his citizenship through a Georgia representative instead.

When Grant became President the following term, Longstreet’s friendship with the former General would prove beneficial to him. A month after Grant took office, he appointed Longstreet to be Surveyor of Customs at the Port of New Orleans.¹¹ This marked a key moment in Longstreet’s public image, he had officially entangled himself with a Republican administration — one especially led by the General that had slaughtered Confederate platoons with ease. White Southerners may have been outraged at Longstreet recommending that they take Reconstruction lightly, but this was their last straw with their former leader.

Longstreet had painted a target on his back by softly advocating for Reconstruction and taking a position with the Republican administration. He would soon find himself under attack by his former colleagues that began to blame him for their loss, like General Jubal Early who used a letter that Longstreet wrote after Gettysburg where he criticized Lee’s battle strategy after Lee rejected Longstreet’s own plan.¹² Early would claim that a vindictive Longstreet would sabotage Gettysburg by arriving late to the battle. To Early’s defense came numerous other Confederate leaders to defend Lee and cast Longstreet aside. Longstreet had officially become the scapegoat vilified by his own men for daring to challenge the cult of Robert E. Lee and Southern society.

Longstreet's story is an interesting contour to American Civil War history: the path of a Confederate General, once General Lee's second-in-command, to becoming bullied and ostracized out of the cult of the Confederacy even in modern iconography. When I began this research, it was difficult to assign feelings to Longstreet: is he a friend, or is he a foe? He certainly was not perfect, but almost nobody was back then. His absence in monuments like Stone Mountain continue the legacy painted by Lost Cause ideologues that deified Lee but not Lee's closest military strategist. Undoubtedly, the story of James Longstreet is one that must be investigated and told more often in public history than it actually is.



In 2020, there were discussions of taking down one of the few monuments that Longstreet had in the aftermath of the George Floyd protests.¹³ This was a time with free flowing discourse on the maintenance of Confederate iconography that previously was used as marks of White supremacy roots of our nation's history. But Longstreet's story is not like the others, which enriched the conversation about whether the monument is truly Confederate or a story of the possibility of reconstructed futures. One group came to the defense of the statue—the Longstreet Society.

Then-President Richard Pilcher referred to Longstreet as a "civil rights activist" in his interview with the Gainesville Times. A building dedicated to the preservation of life and history to the impugned Longstreet, a form of public history to a figure that definitely deserved some respect for standing firm against hordes of white supremacists in the Battle of New Orleans. Yet, something felt off about the experience. In fact, it took a lot of reflection to finally point out what I had noticed.

In the following pages, through the use of images and text, I take you through a paper journey through the Longstreet Society, its uncomfortable nature, and the faults of academic public history that are symbolized in this museum.



THE HISTORIC PIEDMONT HOTEL

PART ONE

The Overall Narrative

The Piedmont Hotel was constructed just prior to the opening of the nearby railroad in 1873. Primarily a summer resort, the three-story hotel was a rambling building with 30 rooms. A large dining room and a billiard room were also included. Confederate General James Longstreet (1821-1904) owned and operated the hotel for almost 20 years following the Civil War. During this time, as Georgia's most influential Republican Party leader, Longstreet hosted a number of notable 19th century Americans at the hotel, including Union General and New York Congressman Daniel Sickles, Confederate General Joseph Johnston, newspaperman Henry Grady and writer Joel Chandler Harris. The hotel's most famous guests were the young Woodrow and Ellen Axson Wilson. Their second daughter Jessie Woodrow was born here on August 28, 1887, in a still-existing room. The need to supply the hotel's demand for its famous fried chicken and other savory chicken dishes is recognized as the motivation for the genesis of the poultry industry in Northeast Georgia. The majority of the hotel building was demolished c. 1918, but in 1994, a run-down duplex apartment building was discovered to be the Piedmont Hotel's lower-level west wing, which contained the room where Jessie Wilson was born.

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Taking the Impossible

Rehabilitation of a Reconstructed Rebel

James Longstreet's story and narrative in history is a difficult one. Despised by Northerners and Southerners, his reconstruction sets him in an interesting place.



The Piedmont Hotel

Longstreet's name will forever be a charged term in American Civil War history. Anyone that knows of his life story will have strong feelings to support or oppose him, but taking a step outside of the debate provides an academic insight on how dealing with a narrative like Longstreet's is difficult. There are only two methods to handle this narrative.



The Side Entrance of the Piedmont Hotel

Casting Longstreet as a Rehabilitated Rebel will be difficult for those that abhor the Confederacy. While he stood beside Republicans when they oversaw Reconstruction and the bestowment of civil liberties to Black Americans, he also stood with those that fought to maintain the racial hierarchy. His grand title — Lieutenant General of the Confederacy — will forever haunt his ability to be accepted by a wider audience as the South's model reconstructed rebel.

Returning back to the 2020 discussion of removing his Gainesville, GA statue, it becomes clear that speaking about James Longstreet is treated equally as if we were speaking about any other Confederate leader. The question of whether this treatment is fair depends on the person being asked, but it is undeniable that Longstreet qualifies as a form of uncomfortable history that is taboo in a post-George Floyd era.

Longstreet is not necessarily a “good” Confederate but he's better than his peers and had some good changes of heart later in life. Still, this discussion will leave a headache if we try to place him into a set spot in history using modern beliefs. The only answer that can be drawn through this line of thought is a simple non-answer:

Rehabilitation of General James Longstreet as a Reconstructed Rebel is impossible because this discourse is too complex to simply say that he's worthy or not worthy of rehabilitation. There just simply isn't an answer.

Providing the Reality

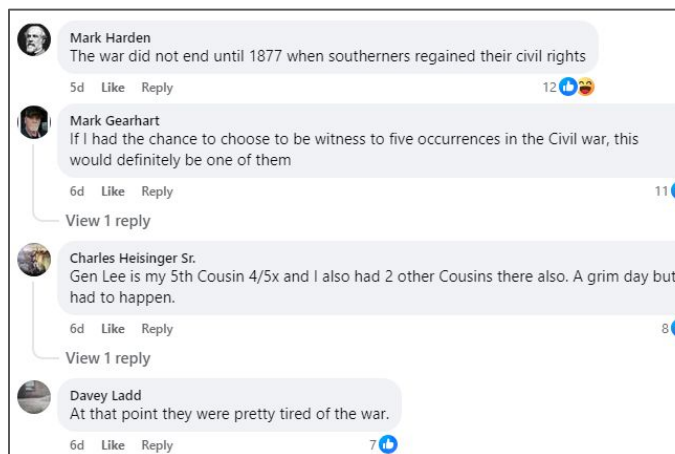
Rehabilitation of an Unreconstructed Rebel

Teaching the story of a Reconstructed Rebel is difficult in contemporary politics, but rehabilitating a rebel that was never reconstructed is made easier because of this.

But what about for those that still venerate the Confederacy? For them, their answer is still somewhat difficult but less so with a recentering of discussion. In fact, James Longstreet serves as a trojan horse to the modern Lost Cause.

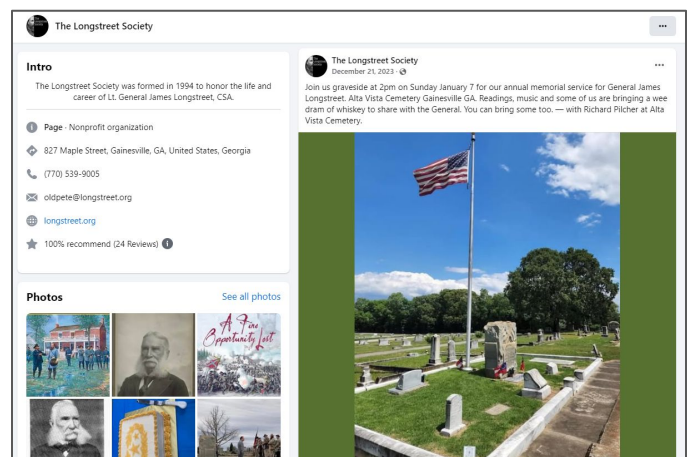


Celebration of Longstreet in January 2025
(Photo Credit: Megan Wade)



Recent Comments on the Longstreet Society Facebook

In fairness to the Longstreet Society, they have, from time to time, fought off commenters who have spread anti-Union sentiments.

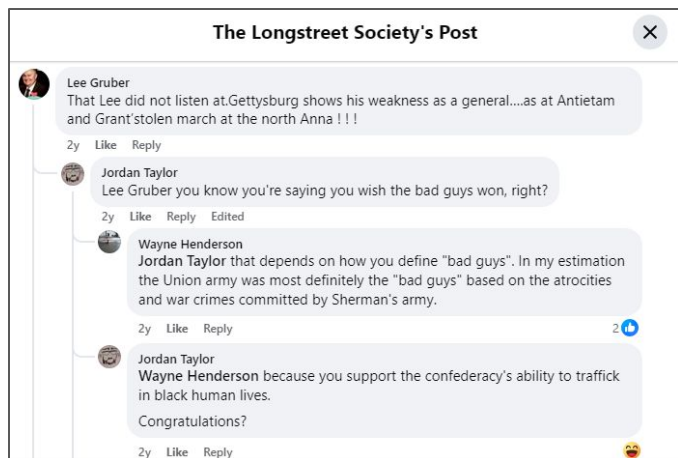


The U.S. Flag flying on Longstreet's grave, posted by the Longstreet Society Facebook Page.



Comments on the Above Post

Still, it becomes obvious that the Longstreet story is hijacked by sympathizers to the Confederacy in spite of the actual story.



Comments on the Longstreet Society's Facebook

To these commenters, Longstreet is a memory device that is used for their present justification of the Lost Cause and any future adoration of the Confederacy. History has been subverted by their politics and the Piedmont Hotel is the memory site to their use of his story.

You cannot be a supporter of the Confederacy and of James Longstreet unless you erode the history behind Longstreet's service after the war and his treatment by Confederate leadership. Yet, this is the case for these commenters.

This context is most important for any visitor that comes into the Piedmont Hotel's reach: the exhibits should not be taken at face value, they provide a deeper meaning with an unsettling tone to their purpose in American Civil War memory.

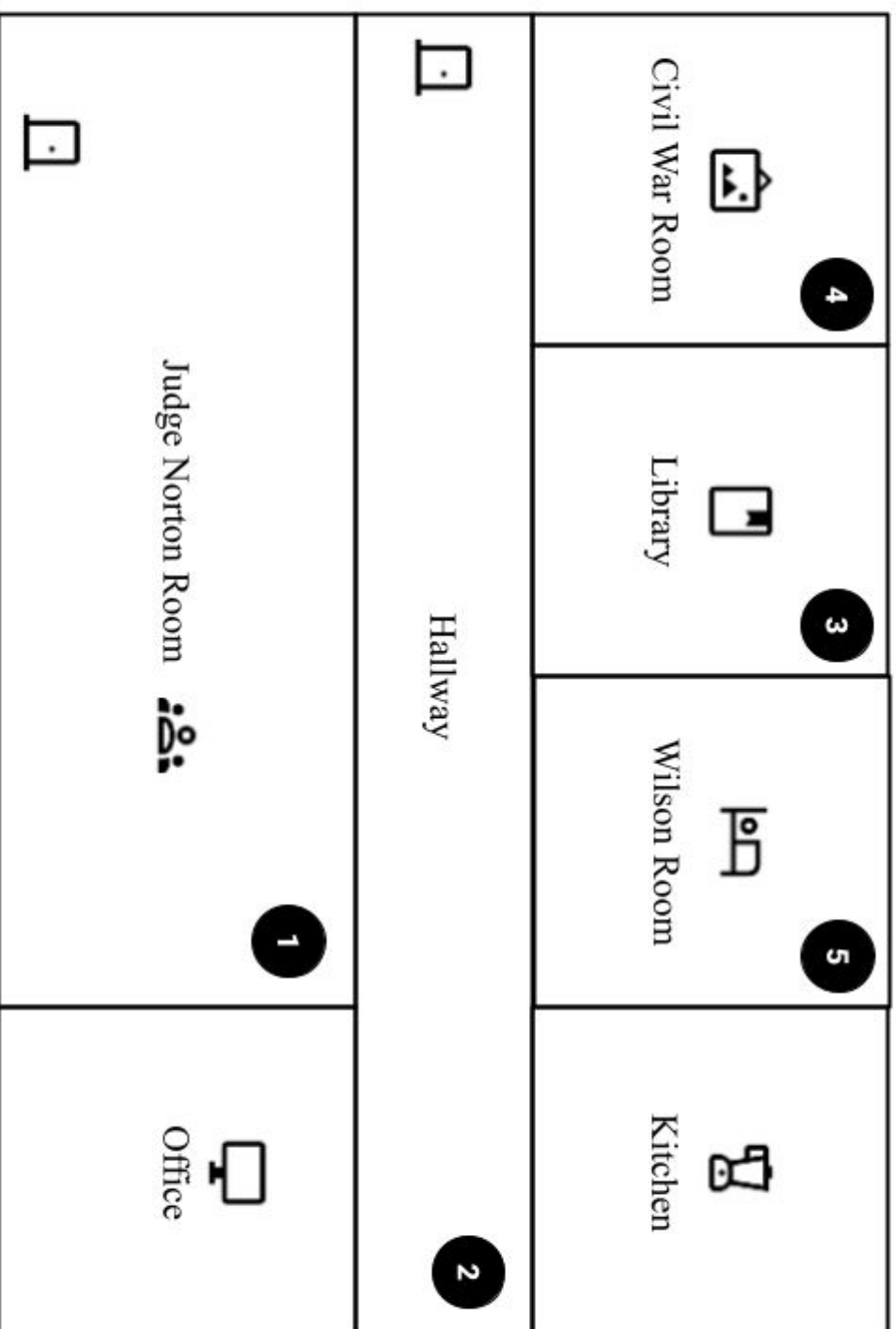
A dark, monochromatic photograph of a porch. In the foreground, a wooden rocking chair is partially visible on the left. In the background, another rocking chair and a rocking horse are visible. A small sign with the word "OPEN" hangs on the wall to the left. The text "PART TWO" is centered in a large, bold, white font, and "The Rooms" is centered below it in a smaller, italicized, white font.

PART TWO

The Rooms

The Piedmont Hotel

Museum Floor Map



The Museum Hallway

Retelling General Longstreet's Story

The Piedmont Hotel hallway retells the story of James Longstreet under the terms of the Longstreet Society, but the story is missing something.



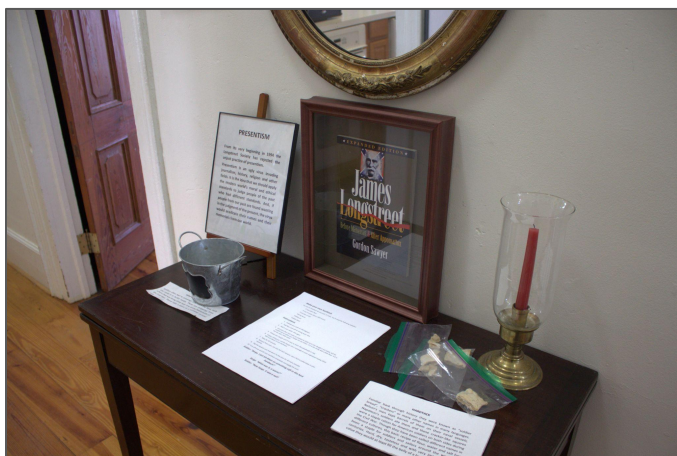
The Piedmont Hotel Hallway

The Piedmont Hotel floor plan can be described as one long hallway with multiple rooms branching off to serve their own part to the overarching narrative of the Longstreet Society. This structure places the hallway and its displays as the prominent part of the curated narrative, and so it displays the most pictures related to Longstreet.

The hallway gives a short summary of the life of General Longstreet and his close ones, such as a section of the wall dedicated to his family tree and one part solely for his second wife Helen Dortch, who dedicated her entire life to defending her husband from Lost Cause attacks on his reputation. It becomes clear in the design of the museum that the hallway is the narrative that the Longstreet Society wishes to impress on its visitors.



Copies of Longstreet's Commissions



The Piedmont Hotel Hallway



Confederate Imagery

So, why is there no mention of Longstreet's service after the war? There is a surprising lack of imagery of Longstreet's service after the war, something that there is definitely no shortage of. Not even his character assassination for becoming a Republican after the war is present. Longstreet is one of our contours: but that contour is missing in this hallway.



Posted Sign on Historical Presentism

One thing that *is* present in this hallway is a posted sign warning the visitor on the dangers of historical presentism: the act of applying contemporary morality standards to acts of the past.

The absence of Longstreet's service in New Orleans is unfortunate, but the inclusion of a warning on presentism is suspect. Why decline to include the actual instances that made Longstreet interesting but make commentary to ask the visitor not to cast judgment on the actions of the past?



Newspaper of Longstreet's Woes

The Longstreet Library

Accessibility and James Longstreet

If a history tree falls down in a secluded wooded area, would it make a sound? How does History function when it is not easily accessible to the public?



The Longstreet Library in the Piedmont Hotel

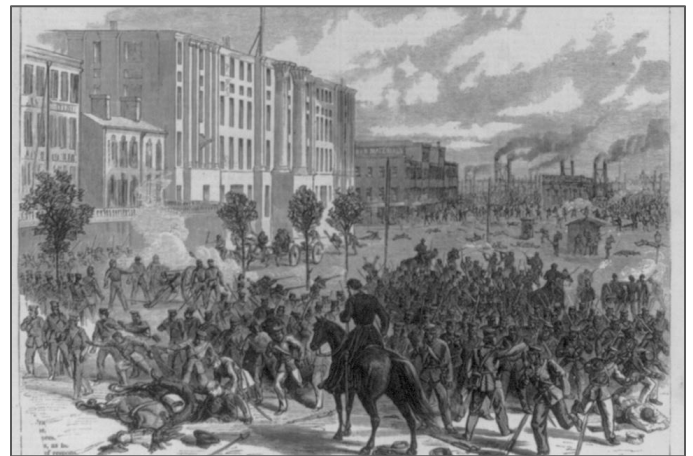
The only room that has material related to James Longstreet's service as a Republican is the library, which holds many books and research compilations. Asking a museum visitor, especially someone with a mere passive interest, to read a whole book or scholarly article to get a full picture is impossible.



Assorted Books in the Longstreet Library

If they spent time reading in the library, they'd learn about Longstreet in New Orleans leading an integrated police force against a White Supremacist insurrection that temporarily deposed the Governor of Louisiana after claiming election fraud had illegally made him the victor.

Asking a museum visitor, especially someone with a mere passive interest, to read a whole book or scholarly article to get a full picture is impossible.



James Longstreet leading the New Orleans Metro Police against the White League insurrection. Credit: Wikimedia

A visitor that comes into the Piedmont Hotel will remember the pictures of Confederate iconography, photos of James Longstreet in the Civil War, and the war stories. They will not recall the books that tell another story.

This room, though just a bunch of books on shelves, tells more of a story of the Piedmont Hotel. Its context is vital to a better understanding of History.

The Civil War Rooms

The Hijacking of Narrative

Academic history is absent in the Piedmont Hotel except for its Longstreet Library. This absence has allowed a tone of Confederate iconography to hijack Longstreet's story.



The "Awkward" Room

To associate James Longstreet with the modern Confederate movement is, as I mentioned previously, a metaphorical mixing of oil and water. This room, which I've nicknamed as the "awkward" room, makes this mixture.

There is no mention of James Longstreet in this room.

This room **celebrates** Longstreet's Confederacy status, not what made him special. Instead of a room for his Republican service, there is a room to celebrate the Confederacy that had rejected Longstreet.

This room attracts Lost Cause followers and is why they appear on the museum's Facebook page.



Confederate Iconography in the "Awkward" Room



The "Awkward" Room



Civil War Memorabilia

Judge Norton's Room

History's Endemic Financial Obstacles

The politics behind which institutions get sufficient financial backing to operate and where they get that help from is most evident in the Longstreet Society.



The Main Entrance of the Piedmont Hotel

General James Longstreet started his military career in the United States Army earning commendation and promotion through the ranks in the Mexican-American war. His life seemed absent of the political strife that would eventually lead to armed conflict, except for his upbringing. Longstreet was raised in his later youth by his uncle, Augustus Baldwin Longstreet, who was a “passionate advocate of states’ rights” and friends with secessionist John C. Calhoun. This would motivate Longstreet’s decision to join the Confederacy when rebellion would call for abled-bodied men.

Longstreet would become an essential military leader to the Confederacy. Other Confederate Generals would commend Longstreet’s service and dedication to the Southern cause. During this time, Longstreet was acceptable to the Lost Cause and Southern History. Otherwise, he is a pariah that cannot be included in a Southerner’s history.

This room is dedicated to Judge Norton for his help in setting up the Longstreet Society by paying off a loan that jeopardized the museum some time ago. Norton’s contribution, made from his own pocket, salvaged the Piedmont Hotel from closure.



Civil War Memorabilia in the Norton Room

Museum leadership spoke to me about how Norton was a key figure in the museum’s history by that decision, but that he also played a role in molding the museum based on his vision for the group. This stepped on some feathers as Judge Norton’s vision would contradict the goals of a historical society.

Norton apparently made a number of changes, even without consulting the Longstreet Society’s leaders. In one instance, he wanted to create a group called the “Longstreet-Wilson Center for Peace and Reconciliation” in the Piedmont Hotel named after General Longstreet and President Woodrow Wilson, whose relation will be spelled out later in this compilation.

Norton paid for the installation of a sign on the lawn promoting the Longstreet Society and his proposed institute, which did not sit well with leadership. Their goal was to turn the Piedmont Hotel into a museum and document repository on the life of their beloved Longstreet. Norton's plans expended resources and would absorb time away from these goals.



The Longstreet Society's Installed Sign

After Norton died, museum leadership painted over the institute name on the bottom of the sign.

Though his plans never came into fruition, museum leadership emphasized their inability to reject their financier's plans. This problem has haunted public history for a long time: the fact that "[a]ll funding comes with conditions." Judge Norton, though interested in historic preservation, was not an academic trained in the ethics of public history nor in the discipline of history itself. Despite this, he was given a seat on the table with equal authority to those that led the museum.

Using his authority, Norton pushed for a bigger inclusion of America's racist grandparent turned President, Woodrow Wilson, despite that he abhorred Reconstruction. Placing Wilson's name beside James Longstreet is a historical mixing of oil and water in light of Longstreet's service after the war as a Republican in New Orleans. Still, the decision was made by the museum's key donor.

Many of the curatory decisions in the Piedmont Hotel involve some level of Judge Norton's hand.

Norton's dedication to historic preservation is still admirable even if he may have obstructed it with his suggestions, but his figure is a perfect illustration of public history's own problems on funding public history projects. His decision to save the Piedmont Hotel salvaged this project — a project that, on its face, should be saved. James Longstreet serves as a contour of civil war history that enriches discourse and teaches for the future: the possibility of reform of a moment of dark history.



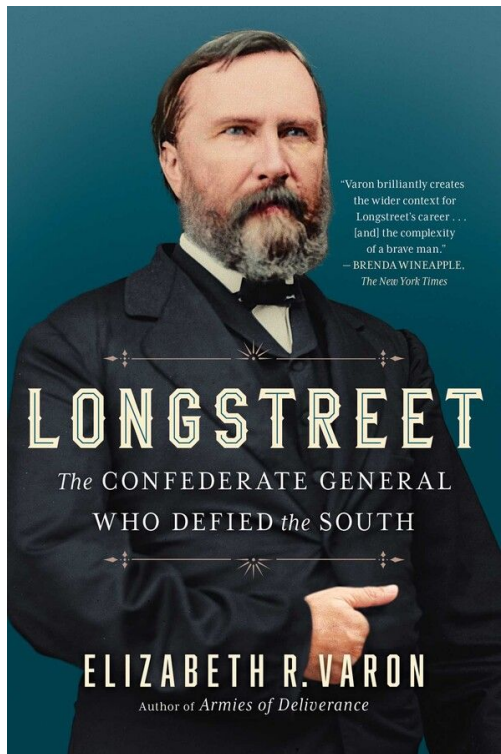
Fundraising Brochures in the Norton Room

The Norton Room is now used for events and has some fundraising material used to ask for in-kind donations from visitors. Its current use is an eerie remnant of a museum with more creative control but still obedient to its audience if it wishes to keep operations. These chains remain prevalent in current Public History: deal with the politics of donors or the demands of your audience through ticket sales and donations?



The Norton Room

Further Reading

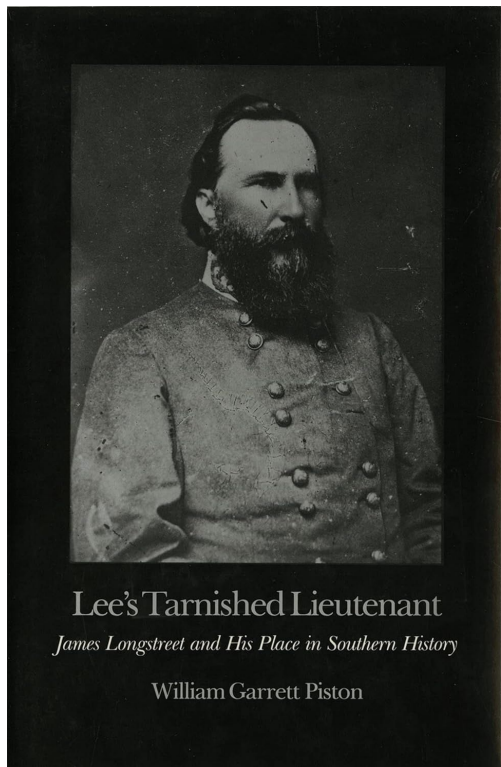


Longstreet: The Confederate General Who Defied the South

By Elizabeth R. Varon (2023)

This book is the most recent biography on General James Longstreet and explores beyond his life into the role he plays in Civil War memory, iconography, and his role as a counter icon against the Lost Cause mythology. Monuments have a significant place in her methodology of examining Longstreet's defial of the South's cult around Robert E. Lee.

Dr. Varon is a Professor of History at the University of Virginia and has written extensively in academic journals on James Longstreet, as well as made many appearances on television to discuss the American Civil War and James Longstreet.



Lee's Tarnished Lieutenant: James Longstreet and His Place in Southern History

By William Garrett Piston (1987)

Piston's book is separated into two parts: the first part which examines General Longstreet's war service record and the second part which reviews Longstreet's place in Southern History as a scalawag attacked by the Lost Cause ideologues. This book makes great look at Longstreet's fame after death and how he became hated by Southerners.

Dr. Piston is a former Professor of History at Missouri State University who specialized in American Civil War History. He was taught under Thomas L. Connelly, a scholar and historian of the Lost Cause. His book played a major role in Elizabeth Varon's book.

